

YOUR FIRST READING IS NOT THE WHOLE STORY.

*Why your body decides what a moment means
before you do*

TIME · ATTENTION · SAFETY



STATE NOT SITUATION

YOUR BODY SPEAKS FIRST
YOUR MIND EXPLAINS SECOND

SAME LIFE. DIFFERENT INSTRUMENT SETTINGS.



Ivana Budišin

CLINICAL PSYCHOLOGIST

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With a foreword by Dr Kristina Herber

BUDISIN PUBLISHING

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Published by Budisin Publishing

Book design and typesetting: Ivana Budišin

Cover design: Zoe Larusson

Foreword: Dr Kristina Herber, AIHE Academic Institute for Higher Education

Legal deposit: Bibliothèque nationale du Luxembourg

ISBN-13: 978-2-87996-258-0

On the evening of 16 July 1999, a small single-engine plane took off from New Jersey. It was heading for Martha's Vineyard. The pilot was experienced enough to be confident and new enough to be wrong about what that confidence meant. He had about 300 hours in the air. He had not finished the training that would qualify him to fly using only his instruments.

The sky was clear when he departed so he concluded that he did not need instruments. By the time he reached the coast, a haze had settled over the water. The mist, the one that erases the line between sea and sky so gradually that you do not notice the horizon is gone until you look for it and it is not there. Over land there are lights below. You see roads, buildings, a geometry that tells your eyes which way is down. Over open water at night, with haze sitting on the surface like a second darkness, there is nothing. The world outside the cockpit becomes a uniform grey in every direction. Up looks like down. A gentle turn feels like level flight. A slow descent feels like holding steady.

The pilot's inner ear, the organ that tells the brain which way the body is oriented in space, works by detecting changes in motion. When you enter a turn, the fluid inside the ear shifts, and the brain registers rotation. But if the turn holds steady for fifteen or twenty seconds, the fluid in the inner ear settles. It stops moving. The brain, which tracks movement, concludes that the turn has ended. You feel level, but you are not.

Somewhere over the dark water, the plane entered a gentle left turn. The pilot's instruments, the dials on the panel in front of him, showed the turn. The artificial horizon, a small gyroscope display that shows the aircraft's angle relative to the earth, was telling him clearly that he was banking. The altimeter was telling him he was descending. The airspeed indicator was telling him he was accelerating. His body was telling him something different. His body was telling him he was flying straight and level. His body felt right. His instruments felt wrong. He trusted his body.

The turn tightened. The nose dropped. The airspeed built. In the final seconds, the plane was descending at more than 4,700 feet per minute, nearly a mile every sixty seconds, in a tightening spiral that pilots call, with the grim precision of a profession that has named the ways it loses people, a graveyard spiral. He hit the water at full speed. He and his two passengers were killed on impact.

The investigation found no mechanical failure. The engine was running. The instruments were working. The data was right there, on the panel, six inches from his eyes, the whole time, but he did not read it. He read his body instead. The American Federal Aviation Administration's instruction to pilots who find themselves in this situation is one sentence long. It is a literal instruction that applies to your life as directly as it applies to a cockpit:

“have confidence in your instruments and ignore all conflicting signals your body gives you.”

The pilot's name was John F. Kennedy Jr. He was the son of an American president. He had been advised not to fly that night without his instructor. He told his instructor he wanted to do it alone. He was thirty-eight years old.

You operate a body that produces signals and your mind often treats those signals as truth. The signals are sometimes as wrong as the inner ear's vestibular system over dark water. The tiredness that presents itself as a question about your career. The caffeine spike that presents itself as anxiety about an email. The low blood sugar that presents itself as evidence that your relationship is failing. Your body speaks first and your mind explains second. The explanation, because it comes with the full weight of physical conviction, the tight jaw, the fast heartbeat, the heat behind the ears, feels like deep knowledge. It feels like you are reading the situation. But you are only reading the instrument that is reading the situation, and the instrument's settings were off before the situation arrived. These instruments exist. You have

them. Heart rate, jaw tension, breathing depth, shoulder position, the speed of your thoughts. They are producing data right now, as you read this sentence. But the body's confident weather report about the world is only a draft.

THE FIRST MISREADING

Nothing went wrong on this day.

The instruments were working.
The data was there the whole time.

THIS BOOK IS THE

Investigation.

THE SAME DAY, FIVE READINGS

- 
- 06:38 A heaviness arrives before the day does.
 - 09:12 A two-line email reads like a judgement.
 - 14:23 Five neutral words tighten a jaw.
 - 17:45 An unanswered message starts charging cognitive rent.
 - 22:47 Two letters and a full stop feel hostile.

THE BODY SPEAKS FIRST.

THE MIND EXPLAINS SECOND.

A MAP OF THE BOOK

The Investigation

16 CASES. THREE READINGS.
ONE QUESTION: STATE OR SITUATION?

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SAME LIFE. DIFFERENT INSTRUMENT SETTINGS.

You Know the Day

A day with a crisis has a shape. It has an exact problem that makes demands and it gives you something to push against. You would know what to do with a crisis. You have done it before. The day I mean is the other kind. The day where nothing went wrong and everything felt off. It started before you noticed it starting. Somewhere between the alarm and the shower, between the shower and the kitchen, between the kitchen and the first sip of whatever you drink to become the person the morning requires. Something was already there. It felt more like texture. A drag in the limbs, a reluctance in the chest, a faint heaviness that sat behind your thoughts like rainy weather behind glass. You pulled on your clothes and drove to work or sat at your desk or made the school run. You carried that feeling the way you carry a background headache. That texture was enough to change the feeling of everything it touched that day.

You have had it dozens of times and you will have it again and each time the story will feel like the truth and each time the morning after will make the story dissolve. You will not stop to wonder why because by then, the next day will have arrived with its own weather and its own stories. The mechanism that produced yesterday's will be invisible again.

The story that is built on a day like this is not random. It is the settings on the instrument that reads your life and the settings were off that day. The body spoke first. The mind explained second, and this explanation felt like the event.

§

This book is about that mistake. It is about that error as a daily, ambient, invisible feature of being alive in a body that is constantly producing signals, which your mind is constantly reading or misreading. Before any of that, before the science and the mechanism and the reason the instrument was miscalibrated

yesterday, try something right now. Whatever you are feeling as you read this sentence. Check your jaw. Check your breath. Check your shoulders. What you found is a reading. A reading of the instrument that is interpreting everything around you, in this moment, including these words. The reading may be accurate. It may not. You cannot know until you have seen the settings. Is this the situation? Or is this the state?

Before We Begin

This book makes claims about the brain and the body and those claims carry different amounts of evidence. Some rest on decades of replicated research. Some rest on newer findings that are promising but not yet settled. Some claims are plausible extensions of established science that have not been directly tested in the specific form this book describes. You should know which is which.

Throughout the book scientific claims carry a confidence marker. When a finding rests on solid, replicated evidence, you will see a graphic marked as *high evidence* and illustrated with a deep red heartbeat in the margin. When the evidence is suggestive but incomplete it is noted as *medium evidence* with an orange heartbeat. When a claim is a plausible hypothesis that needs stronger tests, it is marked as *low* in faded grey. These markers exist because the book's own risk is the same risk it describes. It does not want to treat a plausible story as settled truth. These markers are a brake on that.



H I G H



M E D I U M



L O W

The chapters that follow are organised around three systems that shape how your body's signals get weighted before your mind builds a story. They are not brain regions or neural pathways. They are a sorting tool, a way to ask three questions when everything feels wrong at once. The first is *Time*. Sleep, food, caffeine, circadian phase, recovery. When the timing is off, baseline sensitivity

rises. The same world feels harsher. The second is *Attention*. The system that tracks reward, novelty, and the next cue. When it is captured, focus narrows to the cheapest available input, and the expensive work feels hard. The third is *Safety*. The system that monitors threat, and especially social threat. Things like social evaluation, exclusion, ambiguity, status. It is fast, it is old, and it is biased toward false alarms. It produces interpretations that feel like facts.

In the brain, these three systems overlap constantly. Sleep loss degrades threat assessment, which fragments attention, which worsens threat assessment. The separation exists for you, the reader, because when everything feels wrong at once, having three questions to ask is more useful than having one, or none. The chapters treat each system independently, the way a mechanic checks the battery, the alternator, and the fuel system separately, even though all three share the same electrical spine. The system is entangled and it is illustrated separately for easier understanding.

Some chapters will offer you something you can test. If the model of the psychological mechanism is right, you will notice something specific. If it is wrong for you, that is equally useful information. Both outcomes are data. Each test comes with a stop rule. If tracking worsens your sleep, your anxiety, your rumination, or your functioning, you stop. The measurement is supposed to reduce load, not add to it. If the tool produces the anxiety it is supposed to diagnose, the measurement has become the load. Put the tool down. The model will still be here when you are ready to pick it up again. This book does not replace professional support and it does not treat complex conditions as lifestyle problems. It works in the gap between fine and clinical, the space where most people live on most days. If your state does not shift after addressing timing, attention, and safety, or if the heaviness persists across well-rested, well-fed, low-stress days, the framework is not sufficient. Seek support. The model knows its limits.

A note on scope. Research on constructed emotion, including *Lisa Feldman Barrett's work, suggests that bodily sensation and interpretation are not cleanly separable processes. What feels like a signal is already shaped by prior learning and expectation. The instrument panel used in this book is an analogy. The instrument is described as a system configured by experience. The framework does not attempt to resolve that theoretical debate. It operates in a narrower window, in the interval between early activation and the narrative that hardens around it. Even if sensation and meaning are intertwined from the outset, there can still be opportunities to reconsider an interpretation before acting on it. In daily life, we have no cockpit panel that settles the question. We can compare bodily sensations with observable facts before deciding what they mean. This book is concerned with those moments.

THREE WAYS TO READ A MOMENT

- TIME What came before this moment? Sleep, meals, caffeine, recovery, the hour.
- ATTENTION What keeps pulling me back? A message, a thought, a cue, an unfinished task.
- SAFETY What seems at stake? What have I observed, what am I assuming, and does anything need action?

The colours map the chapter: blue is Time, gold is Attention, red is Safety. A longer band marks the main focus of the case. It is editorial emphasis, not a measurement of anyone's state.

Margin heartbeats refer to research evidence. Where to turn when... (page 241) helps you choose a case to revisit.

*Lisa Feldman Barrett is a psychologist and emotion researcher at Northeastern University. Her work asks how the brain constructs emotional experience. I return to it because it challenges a simple split between bodily feeling and interpretation—the limit of the analogy used here.

HOW TO READ THE CASES



00

15

Sixteen cases. One way of reading them.

BEFORE YOU READ

Each opener names the case's three loops and gives you one question. The coloured bar shows the chapter's emphasis.

THE HEARTBEATS

The margin markers indicate the evidence supporting specific claims. The notes at the back list the sources and their limits.

A NAME FOR IT

Each chapter ends with a name for what you have just read: what it is, how it shows up, where the book explains it, and one thing to try. All sixteen are listed on page 292.

WHERE YOU ARE

Occasional stopping pages connect the cases. The two Readings pages gather what they offer, and Where to turn when... helps you choose a case to revisit.

00

A Day That Should Have Been Fine

Katrin wakes at 06:38, two minutes before the alarm. She knows immediately that something is off. The word she would use, if anyone asked, is heavy. The room is the same room. The ceiling is the same ceiling. The pale square of light behind the curtain is the same pale square it has been every morning since the clocks went back in October. But today the distance between lying here and standing up feels wider than it should. As if the day has already started charging before she has agreed to participate.

Katrin went to bed at 23:50. By drift and not by decision. The evening extended the way evenings do. One more episode and one more scroll. Finally she fell asleep around 00:15. The alarm is set for 06:40. That leaves six hours and twenty-three minutes for sleep,

before any time spent awake in the night. She does not track this number, but she knows the feeling. Not rested, not destroyed, just slightly less than the minimum her system needs to run cleanly. She is already forming a theory about why the morning is heavy. The theory will seem reasonable. She will act on it for the next three hours. She will not think about the sleep again, but it will keep working anyway. This is *time*, and it is already running in the background.

06:52. Kitchen. Coffee first, before food. This is habit, not decision. The kettle is closer than the fridge, the mug is where it always is, and the motor sequence that produces coffee in this kitchen has been running for four years. The habit does not consult her about whether today might be a toast-before-coffee kind of day. She drinks the coffee standing at the counter, scrolling through her phone with one hand. The phone is there and her thumb knows what to do. The screen lights up, the feed loads, and for three minutes she is somewhere floating over the kitchen, not reading, not choosing, just sampling. She has not decided to do this. The hand decided. This is *attention*, and it does not require her permission.

She showers, and somewhere between the shampoo and the towel, about twenty minutes after the first sip, the coffee begins to land. Something shifts. It is not wakefulness exactly. Something closer to acceleration. Her heart rate rises slightly. Her hands carry a faint charge. It feels like readiness in the fingers that has no task. Her thoughts begin to move faster than the morning requires. She is alert. Her system is wired but not grounded. Speed without stability, readiness without direction. She has not eaten. The coffee arrived on an empty stomach, and she will not connect any of this to the coffee. She will connect it to the day.

07:25. The commute. Katrin takes the bus, which is twenty-eight minutes when the traffic is ordinary and forty when it is not. Today it is thirty-four. It is neither good nor bad. But Katrin will experience it as slow. Something in her is running fast this morning, and when you are running fast on the inside, the external world feels like it

is dragging. On the bus she checks her email. There is one from her manager, David, sent at 07:12, which says *can we find 15 min today? Nothing urgent*. She reads it twice.

The first reading is informational. The second reading is interpretive. And the interpretation is already being shaped by whatever it is she has been carrying since 06:38. The heaviness. The coffee edge. The morning that has not settled. “Nothing urgent” should be reassuring, but it is the opposite, because “nothing urgent” combined with “can we find 15 min” creates ambiguity that her nervous system, in its current state, cannot leave alone. If it were urgent, she would know what to prepare. If it were nothing, he would not have emailed. The message sits in the gap, in the space where her brain begins to fill the gap. Her mind races: *is it the restructure, the project review, the comment she made in Thursday’s meeting that got a laugh (but was the laugh with her or was it the polite kind?), the email she sent last week that she now thinks was too direct?*

Each possibility arrives as a scenario to be survived. Katrin’s body responds to each one as if it were already happening. A slight tightening in the jaw, a warmth behind the ears, a narrowing of attention onto the worst interpretation. She notices that she is stressed about the meeting with David. She has attributed the feeling, which is real, which is in her body and has a measurable physiology, to the email. The email is the situation. The feeling must be about the situation. But the feeling was there before the email. The heaviness at 06:38. The caffeine edge arriving in the shower. Whatever is running underneath both. The email gave the activation an address. This is *safety*.

08:05. The office. Katrin sits at her desk. Coat off. Laptop open. The office is what offices are at 08:05. Filling slowly, producing the ambient sound of arrival. Bags, chairs, the coffee machine beginning its first cycle, someone’s phone playing something they have not yet silenced. She opens the quarterly report she has been working on since last week. She looks at the paragraph she left mid-sentence on Friday. It is not good. It was not good on

Friday either, but on Friday she had the capacity for two things at once. The knowledge that the paragraph was not good and the confidence that she could make it good. Today she has only the first. The paragraph is not good and it feels like it is about her. About her ability. About whether she is the kind of person who can do this work. Somewhere in the emptiness between the screen and her body, a conclusion is forming, *I am not good enough for this*. The conclusion feels like insight, like the honest, hard truth that she has been avoiding. It said *I am failing*; the data was *I am tired*.

09:30. She eats a sandwich at her desk. She was hungry and the bakery downstairs had the one she likes. Fifteen minutes later, something shifts. The kind of shift that you only notice in retrospect, the way you only notice that a background song was playing when it stops. The jaw loosens by a fraction. The breathing drops. The paragraph, which at 08:05 looked like professional inadequacy, now looks like a paragraph that needs a better opening sentence. She rewrites the sentence. It is not brilliant, but it is adequate, and adequate did not feel available ninety minutes ago.

10:00. She walks to David's office for the fifteen-minute meeting. Her chest tightens in the corridor. One more time. The restructure, the review, the comment from Thursday. David wants to talk about the budget timeline. Her fears about the restructure and her performance now seem out of touch. He needs her numbers by Friday. The meeting takes nine minutes, after which he thanks her and returns to his screen. On the walk back to her desk, she notices the tightness is gone. The building has not changed. The job has not changed. The email, which at 07:25 on the bus felt like the opening of something dangerous, was a short request about a spreadsheet. Same morning. Same paragraph. Same Katrin on different instrument settings.

Three systems ran through Katrin's morning. *Time* started at 06:38 and never stopped. *Attention* took the phone at 06:52. *Safety* wrote the email's meaning at 07:25. She can name none of them. The only thing she can name is David, and David is the smallest part of it.

The Instrument Panel

When the morning feels too expensive to enter, when the paragraph looks like evidence about your character, when the email looks like the beginning of something bad, when the heaviness feels like it means something about who you are, stop. Not for long, stop for five seconds. Notice your jaw. Is it tight or loose? Is your breathing high in the chest or low near the ribs? Are your shoulders lifted or dropped? And your energy, is it flat, wired, or steady? Are your thoughts racing, or are they sluggish? Or ordinary?

Once you have the reading, run the supply chain. Where did this state come from? Sleep, food, caffeine, an unresolved conversation, the time of day? The reading tells you *what* is happening. The supply chain tells you *why*. You are not interpreting or building a story. You are simply measuring. The way a pilot reads the panel before deciding what the turbulence means. This is *reading mode*. It comes before the story. Every chapter in this book is about extending the seconds you spend here before *narrating mode* takes over.

Katrin's reading, at 08:05, if she had taken it, would have shown a tight jaw, breathing high, shoulders lifted, energy wired but hollow, thoughts racing. That is not the profile of a woman who is failing, but rather the profile of a nervous system running on insufficient sleep and too much caffeine on an empty stomach. The reading would not tell her the email is fine. It would tell her that she is not in a state to accurately assess whether the email is fine. The reading creates a small space between the body's report and the story the mind is building. And in that gap, better decisions become possible.

State. Not situation.

Have a look at your dashboard reading now. Jaw, is it clenched, loose, or somewhere between? Do not change it, just notice. Breath, where is it sitting? High in the chest, or low near the ribs? How deep? Do not fix it. Just read it. Shoulders, where are they? Lifted, dropped, pulled forward? Notice what they are doing without asking

them to do something else. Whatever you found is not a problem to solve, but something this book calls a *reading*. It is a report from the instrument that is about to interpret the next chapter, the next email, the next conversation you walk into tonight.

A NAME FOR IT / 00

Narrating mode

The mind explaining a feeling with a story, and taking the story for the event. It starts on its own, and it feels like observing. Its opposite is reading mode: a plain look at what the body is doing, before the story.

HOW IT SHOWS UP

- A short email becomes a verdict.
- An unfinished paragraph becomes “I am not good enough for this.”
- A slow bus becomes a bad day.

IN THE BOOK

Pages 13 to 15. Sources, page 243.

TRY IT

Choose one difficult moment. Separate what happened from what you brought to it: a short night, hunger, an unfinished conversation.

CHAPTER 01 FOLLOWS

The Radar Was Right

STATE NOT SITUATION

PUBLISHING 15 OCTOBER 2026

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